



Baptism by fire: In Delhi colours, Yogesh faced the pressure that would harden him into the 'silent killer'.

straightforward. "You have to play with patience. Don't be too aggressive; wait for the right moment to pounce. Play for your team, not for yourself. When my team needs me to tackle, I tackle," he explains.

Hailing from Pahladpur in Haryana, Yogesh's journey from village life to the PKL stage was never mapped out. It began in 2018. "My school seniors used to play in the village. I got interested in kabaddi after watching them. I was never really interested in studies, so it was a good way to get out of doing schoolwork, and I genuinely enjoyed it," he admits with a laugh.

At first, his family saw little point in a boy chasing a sport no one in the household had played. But as his performances improved, their scepticism gave way to full support, matching the steady rise of his career. His first real push came from

his cousin Rohit. "He motivated me to start playing seriously. He constantly guided me, offered advice regularly, and worked incredibly hard with me during the COVID period." That mentorship became the bedrock of Yogesh's game.

Soon he joined a nearby academy in Ganaur, sharpened his skills, and broke into Haryana's squad for the Junior Nationals in 2023. There, coach Anup Kumar spotted him and picked him for the India team at the Junior World Cup.

"It was like a dream come true. I couldn't believe it. I always dreamed of wearing the India jersey," Yogesh recalls. In a tense final, India overcame Iran to win the trophy in its first appearance.

"The entire campaign felt like a

dream. I had to pinch myself after the final. I gave my best performance of the tournament in the final when the team was under pressure. That time, I thought I was ready to play against the big boys."

Days later, then Dabang Delhi coach Rambir Singh Khokhar called to sign him as a New Young Player (NYP) ahead of PKL 10.

"When I got the call and coach sir introduced himself, I was excited. Without even wasting a second, I told him that I'm in," says Yogesh with a playful smile. But the dream start quickly turned. Overwhelmed by the crowd, lights, cameras and the constant scrutiny, anxiety blunted his execution. "In PKL, there is a lot of crowd, noise, bright lights, and cameras; they follow you

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